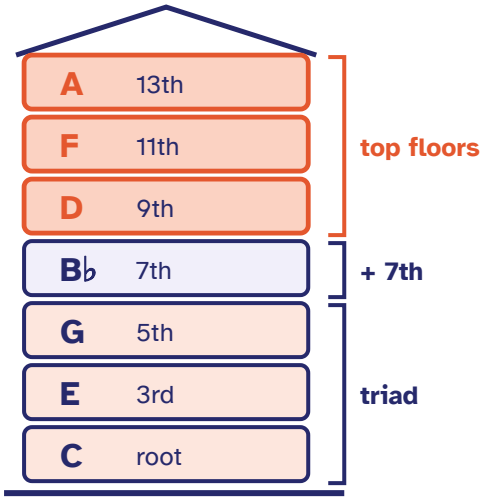
PART IV · HARMONY · 7

The tower: 9, 11, 13

Why stop at the 7th? Keep stacking 3rds and the building grows three more floors: the 9th, the 11th and the 13th. At the top you have used **all seven letters, A to G**.

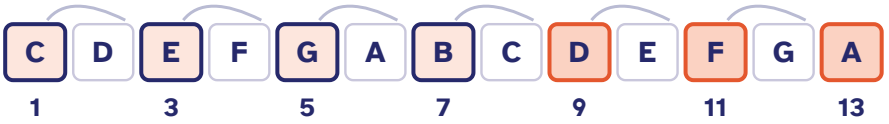
THE SECRET

Keep skipping letters above the 7th: 9, 11, 13 are 2, 4, 6 an octave up.



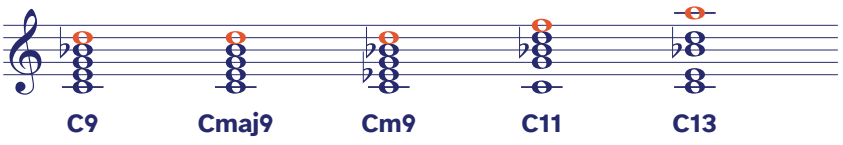
1. Build the seventh chord: **C E G B♭** (C7).
2. Keep skipping one letter: **D**, **F**, **A**. Those floors are the **9th, 11th and 13th**.
3. Take 7 away to find the letter: 9 → 2nd (D), 11 → 4th (F), 13 → 6th (A). Same letters, an octave up.

Skip a letter, all the way up



Start on C and take every other letter: C E G B D F A (letters only: in C7 the B is B♭). After the 13th comes C again: the tower is full.

Five tall chords on C

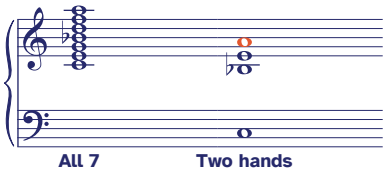


The red note is the top floor that gives each chord its name. C11 and C13 leave some notes out: see p. 105.

CHORD	BUILT AS	NOTES	SOUNDS	HEARD IN
C9	C7 + 9th	C E G B♭ **D**	soulful	funk, soul
Cmaj9	Cmaj7 + 9th	C E G B **D**	dreamy	film, ballads
Cm9	Cm7 + 9th	C E♭ G B♭ **D**	smooth	neo-soul, R&B
C11	C9 + 11th, no 3rd	C G B♭ D **F**	airy	gospel, pop
C13	C7 + 13th	C E B♭ (D) **A**	rich	jazz, blues endings

PART IV · HARMONY · 7 · CONTINUED

Too many notes? Leave some out



All seven notes sound muddy. Two hands play C13 with four: C in the left hand, B♭ E A in the right.

Ten fingers, seven floors: you choose. **Keep** the 3rd and the 7th (they say what kind of chord it is) and the red top note (its colour). **Leave out** the 5th first. The right hand can drop the root too, when the left hand or a bass player plays it.

With a major 3rd, the 11th (F) rubs against E. So C13 leaves out the F. C11 does the opposite: it keeps the F and leaves out the E.

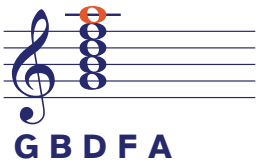
6 or 13? add9 or 9?

SAME TOP NOTE	WITHOUT THE 7TH	WITH THE 7TH (B♭)
A on C	**C6**: C E G A	**C13**: C E B♭ A
D on C	**Cadd9**: C E G D	**C9**: C E G B♭ D

Look for the 7th. No 7th: a colour chord (p. 101). A 7th: a tower chord.

EXAMPLE 1

Name this tall chord: G B D F A



1. **Find the root:** each note skips one letter, so the bottom note, G, is the root.
2. **The first four floors**, G B D F, count 3 + 2 + 2: G7.
3. **One more floor:** A is the 2nd above G, an octave up: the 9th.

G B D F A is **G9**: G7 with the 9th on top.

GAME

Which floor?

1 — the 9th of C

2 — the 11th of C

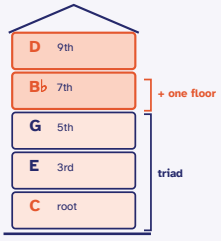
3 — the 13th of C

Build C7 (C E G B♭), then keep skipping one letter above the B♭.

Answer: 1 D · 2 F · 3 A.

PART IV · HARMONY · 7 · CONTINUED

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

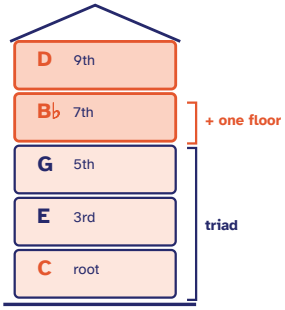


Play C E G B♭ D.

Both hands if you need them: left hand C E G, right hand B♭ D. A C9: the tower with one floor above the 7th.

EXAMPLE 2

Build C9



1. **Build C7:** C E G B♭.
2. **Skip one more letter** above B♭: D.
3. **Five notes:** share them between the hands if you need to.

C9: **C E G B♭ D**, the tower with one floor above the 7th.

HOW TO

Build any tall chord

1. **Start on the root** and skip one letter each time: 1 3 5 7 9 11 13.
2. **Stop** at the number in the name.
3. **Leave out** the 5th first; in a 13th chord, the 11th too, when it is too many notes for your hands.

THINK OF IT A tower block has a lift: you don't stop at every floor. Get out at the 3rd, the 7th and the top floor with the view.

TRAP

- × Hunting far up for the 9th: it is just the 2nd, an octave higher (D on C).
- × Calling C13 a C6: the 13th chord has the 7th (B♭) as well.
- × Playing F and E together in C13 or C11: they clash. C13 drops the F; C11 drops the E.

SEE ALSO

Seventh chords p. 98 · Colour chords p. 101

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Harmony 7 · Online: Library › Chords